



Central Heating Systems



Who designed the central heating system?

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Alice H. Parker is known for patenting a central heating system, that used natural gas. Little is known about Alice's life and upbringing. It is widely considered that her invention played a key role in inspiring the home heating systems that we have today.

Alice H. Parker was an African American inventor in the early 20th century. Alice was born in 1895 in Morristown, New Jersey. She studied at Howard University in Washington, D.C.

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Parker filed her patent in 1919 for her heating system invention. Her design was unique because it used natural gas, not coal or wood, to fuel the heat. In the 1920s, it was a revolutionary idea to use natural gas to power a heating furnace.

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Her design allowed cool air to be drawn into the furnace. This conveyed through a heat exchanger and delivered warm air through ducts to rooms of a house.

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Parker's design included the concept of 'zone heating', where temperature could be controlled in different parts of a building.

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Parker's invention was convenient and heat-efficient. People would not need to go outside to chop wood. The risk of house fires would be reduced. There would be no need to leave a burning fireplace on through the night.

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Parker's receiving of a patent for her invention was an outstanding achievement. At this time, African American women faced many barriers. She filed her patent before the Civil Rights Movement and the Women's Liberation Movement, making her accomplishments even more admirable.

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